

An IM can also be a good business tool, and including your ID on your business card is a good idea. Whether you are a self-employed professional or a businessman or an employee of a company, using IMs for business can save your company (or you) a lot of money for communication. But how is this better than e-mail? For one, instant messaging happens in real-time. If you have to coordinate with a client sitting in another city or country, you could save on long distance calls by using an Instant Messenger.

Some of the popular IMs are MSN Messenger and Yahoo! Messenger. To be able to use these, all you need to do is sign up. The services are free, and you also get an e-mail address upon signup. In the case of MSN, it's Hotmail that gives you a 25 MB mailbox initially (it's about 250 MB if you're in the US), and Yahoo! gives you a 1 GB mail account. Logically, you would rush to sign up for Yahoo!, but it's worthwhile checking up on which of the two is more used within your contacts.

1.3 Using E-Mail

E-mailing is a great tool for keeping in touch and widening you business. But there is a fine line between spamming and being persistent when e-mailing.

Spamming is illegal in most countries, and if your e-mail account is found to be one of those that is spamming, you could well be blocked out by the recipient's mail server, making your efforts futile. Worse still, your own e-mail provider could block you out.

Tip

No matter how rude someone may be to you, or how offended you may be by another's opinion, don't lower yourself to their level by stooping to obscenities, threats or claims of self-importance. Always state your opinion clearly and concisely, without personalising an issue or resorting to name-calling.